realization through which one dispels all illusions and comes to know one's unity with Brahman (the ultimate reality beneath the world of shifting appearances), or by surrendering one's self to God in loving devotion. In Varanasi, it is said, Shiva himself bestows 'instant moksha' by whispering the *taraka* mantra (ferryboat mantra) in the ear of all who die, granting them the requisite knowledge of Brahman.

But this apparent moksha-for-all 'backdoor' poses a major problem. It messes up the law of karmic causation central to orthodox Hinduism. In other words, our deeds in this or previous lives count for nothing. Do the scoundrels who die in Varanasi also gain instant moksha? Doesn't instant moksha also render the priest and his funerary rituals irrelevant to the departing souls (and thereby threaten the livelihood of the priest)?

These questions may seem flippant to some, but the theologians of Hinduism, the pandits, have long struggled for satisfactory answers. One such is to postulate that the moksha is not instant. Before the soul is granted liberation, a short but intense period of post-death suffering occurs in accord with karmic law.[44] So the priest is still required (phew!). In any case, given Varanasi's modest population and the thriving business of funerary priests, it's clear that few Hindus actually believe in this guaranteed 'backdoor' to moksha. Even fewer now, as most 'moksha guesthouses'—where people come to stay in their final days—have shut down or become regular tourist guesthouses.

Chants of 'Ram Naam Sat Hai' reverberate all day on both burning ghats. The bigger, Manikarnika, hosts fifty to sixty cremations a day, which happen round the clock. Some bodies are even flown in from other cities in refrigerated containers. The deceased, wrapped in white cotton and often covered by an ornamental orange shroud and marigold flowers, arrive at the ghat on bamboo biers upon the shoulders of the male kin. The mood is sombre yet business-friendly. Barges with piles of firewood from the forests of MP await unloading in a corner of the ghat. Cows and dogs negotiate the spaces between the mourning kin and funerary workers.

The funerary process is simple and unadorned. Above the ghats are shops staffed by funerary assistants. The kin of the deceased, according to their means, choose one of the funeral packages on offer—each with a certain grade and quantity of firewood, sandalwood or its sawdust, straw, ghee and